Diabetes: An Educational Overview

Types, common signs, diagnosis, and long-term health

Educational information — not a substitute for professional medical advice.

What is diabetes?

Diabetes is a condition in which blood glucose (sugar) is too high because the body does not make enough insulin, cannot use insulin effectively, or both. Insulin helps glucose move from the bloodstream into cells for energy.

Main types

Type 1 diabetes occurs when the immune system destroys insulin-producing cells and insulin treatment is required. Type 2 diabetes involves insulin resistance and/or insufficient insulin production; it is influenced by many genetic, environmental, and lifestyle factors. Gestational diabetes is first recognized during pregnancy. The right diagnosis and treatment depend on clinical assessment and testing.

Common signs

Possible symptoms include increased thirst, frequent urination, increased hunger, unexplained weight loss, fatigue, blurred vision, slow-healing wounds, or recurrent infections. Type 2 diabetes may develop gradually and can be present without obvious symptoms. Symptoms alone cannot confirm diabetes.

Testing and diagnosis

Healthcare professionals may use laboratory tests such as fasting plasma glucose, HbA1c, or an oral glucose tolerance test. Diagnostic cutoffs and the need for repeat confirmation depend on the test and clinical situation. Home glucose meters are useful for monitoring but are not generally used alone to diagnose diabetes.

Why management matters

Over time, elevated glucose can damage blood vessels and nerves and increase the risk of heart disease, stroke, kidney disease, vision loss, and foot problems. Good management can reduce complications and support quality of life.

Treatment and monitoring

Management may include nutrition planning, physical activity, glucose monitoring, medicines, and insulin when indicated. Treatment is individualized by diabetes type, glucose patterns, other conditions, preferences, and access to care. Keep follow-up appointments and discuss medication questions with the care team.

Urgent warning signs

Severe confusion, fainting, difficulty breathing, persistent vomiting, severe dehydration, or inability to keep fluids down can be emergencies. People using insulin or certain glucose-lowering medicines should know how to recognize and treat low blood glucose according to their clinician's plan. Seek urgent help for severe symptoms.

Key points

Diabetes is manageable. Regular follow-up, a personalized care plan, and attention to glucose, blood pressure, cholesterol, kidney health, eyes, and feet are important.

Prepared for general health education. For personal diagnosis or treatment, consult a qualified healthcare professional.